Whichever approach you use to store your application secrets, make sure that you aren't storing them in source control. Even private repositories may not stay private forever, so it's best to err on the side of caution.

Storing secrets in environment variables in production

You can add the environment variable configuration provider by using the `AddEnvironmentVariables` extension method, as you saw in listing 10.4. This method adds all the environment variables on your machine as key-value pairs to `ConfigurationManager`.

NOTE The `WebApplicationBuilder` adds the environment variable provider to the `ConfigurationManager` by default.

You can create the same hierarchical sections in environment variables that you typically see in JSON files by using a colon (`:`) or a double underscore (`__`) to demarcate a section, as in `MapSettings:MaxNumberOfPoints` or `MapSettings__MaxNumberOfPoints`.

TIP Some environments, such as Linux, don't allow the colon in environment variables. You must use the double-underscore approach in these environments instead. A double underscore in an environment variable is converted to a colon when it's imported into the `IConfiguration` object. You should always use the colon when retrieving values from an `IConfiguration` in your app.

The environment-variable approach is particularly useful when you're publishing your app to a self-contained environment, such as a dedicated server, Azure, or a Docker container. You can set environment variables on your production machine or on your Docker container, and the provider reads them at runtime, overriding the defaults specified in your appsettings.json files.